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INTERIM RULERS Iran's head of judiciary Gholam-Hossein Mohseni-Eje'i, president Masoud Pezeshkian and deputy chairman of the Assembly of Experts Alireza Arafi at an undisclosed location after Khameini's death, Mar. 1

had been achieved, Trump then pressed Israel and Iran into agreeing to an uneasy truce 12 days after the war had begun.

Iran used the lull to restock its missile systems and reportedly upgraded its radar network with Chinese aid. Syed Akif Zaidi, a research scholar at Al-Mustafa International University in Qom in Iran, says, "In hindsight, the 12-day war was a godsend. Iran got a chance to test all its military systems, as well as its political and social structures, for a prolonged conflict." But there were costs too. Already under strain from US sanctions, the short war pushed its economy to the verge of collapse. By October, a European vote also brought 'snapback' UN sanctions—the last straw. Inflation soared to 40 per cent, as the Iranian rial depreciated over threefold, from 500,000 rials to the dollar to 1,600,000.

With real wages in free fall and cuts in fuel, bread and electricity subsidies, unprecedented protests erupted. By early January, these had become a nationwide anti-regime movement. The state responded with a brutal crackdown involving the feared Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and its internal security wing, the Basij. Over 7,000 civilians were killed and thousands arrested to stamp out the protests. It exposed the regime's vulnerability and deep internal tensions. Iran appeared at its weakest, internally and externally. As Israel saw it, the iron was hot.

Ever since the horrific attacks by Hamas on Oct. 7, 2023, Israel had moved systematically against Iran's proxies in the region. After reducing Gaza to rubble in its war with Hamas, it turned to Hezbollah in Lebanon and the Houthis in Yemen. Tel Aviv also played a significant role in toppling Bashar al-Assad in Syria, a key Iranian ally. Meanwhile, despite pummelling Iran's nuclear establishment in June 2025, Israel believed Iran's growing missile arsenal had reached a critical threshold beyond which interception would become difficult and costly. Following the January uprisings, Israel judged the moment ripe to cut off what some of its strategists saw as 'the head of the snake', even persuading the US to join forces with it.

ANTICIPATING THE POSSIBILITY OF HIS ASSASSINATION, KHAMENEI HAD BUILT LAYERS OF SUCCESSION NOT ONLY FOR HIS OWN POST BUT ALSO FOR OTHER KEY APPOINTMENTS

TRUMP'S EPIC FURY

Tellingly, Trump launched Operation Epic Fury even as the US and Israel were still engaged in formal negotiations over Iran's nuclear and missile programmes. Although talks seemed to be moving positively, with Iran signalling a willingness to limit its missile capability and reduce its stockpile of enriched uranium, Trump abruptly broke off negotiations, later saying: "We were having negotiations with lunatics and it was my opinion that they were going to attack first." Intelligence reportedly shared by Israel indicated that Iran's Supreme Leader and other senior leaders were getting together at a particular place and time, though timing alone does not explain Washington's broader decision to strike.

In fact, the objectives articulated by the Trump administration have evolved rapidly. Initially, the strikes were framed as a preventive operation designed to cripple Iran's nuclear/ missile infrastructure and neutralise an imminent security threat. But almost immediately, the rhetoric widened to political transformation. In a televised address, Trump called the campaign a human rights mission to save Iran from its "murderous rulers" and openly called on the Iranian public to rise up and "take over your government... it will be yours to take". In a Truth Social post, he further gloated, "Khamenei, one of the most evil people in History, is dead."

The shift towards wanting to trigger regime change marked